political analyst in the studio was a shade sceptical. ‘If power is poison, then why is Rahul Gandhi in politics which is ultimately the pursuit of power?’ I asked.

The answer was given later that evening by Digivjaya Singh who had observed Rahul closely. ‘Rahul is not like any other politician. He doesn’t believe in power, he wants to fight injustice!’ he claimed. I wasn’t convinced. Politics is not about taking sanyas, it is about being a *grihasti*, it’s about taking responsibility by leading from the front. Rahul’s self-identity appears to be of someone who had entered electoral politics not out of choice but compulsion. The contrast with Narendra Modi, who wore his political ambition on his sleeve, could not have been starker.

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Nine months after delivering his ‘power is poison’ speech, Rahul Gandhi showed why he was the second most powerful person in the country at the time. On 27 September 2013, he described an ordinance passed by the Union cabinet that would prevent the instant disqualification of convicted MPs as ‘complete nonsense’. It was an open, blatantly direct and public criticism of the Congress-led Manmohan Singh government which had cleared the controversial ordinance just three days earlier. The prime minister was in Washington at a summit meeting with the US president Barack Obama. The moment he returned a week later, an emergency Cabinet meeting revoked the ordinance.

The ‘nonsense’ remark was made during a press conference at the Press Club of India in Delhi being addressed by the Congress’s communication head and MP, Ajay Maken, who had come there to inaugurate a gymnasium. The press conference had just begun when our Congress beat reporter rang up the newsroom to say that Rahul Gandhi would be making an appearance. At first we thought it was a rumour. Then, mysteriously, Maken got up from the dais and said he had to attend an urgent phone call. Minutes later, Maken was back and smiled. ‘Rahulji will come and address you now on the ordinance.’